



Mongolian Empire

This Italian map shows the empire of the Great Khan. *Chataio* (Cathay in English) was the name used by the Venetian traveler Marco Polo to describe northern China when he journeyed through the empire in the reign of Kublai Khan, Genghis Khan's grandson.

In 1227, while on campaign in Xi Xia, Genghis Khan fell from his horse, became feverish, and died. The vast empire he left to his sons stretched from Iran and Kazakhstan in the west, across central Asia and northern China to the Sea of Japan.

(also known as Ong Khan or “Prince King”), an old ally of his father’s and leader of the Turkish-speaking Kerait people. When Börte was kidnapped,

Temüjin called on Toghrlur for help in rescuing her. Soon afterward, Börte had a baby, Jochi,

who was acknowledged as Temüjin’s son and heir—despite the possibility that he had been conceived while Börte was in captivity.

Campaigns and conquests

Having reclaimed his family’s status and secured Toghrlur’s patronage, Temüjin began to earn his military reputation. Together with Toghrlur, he harassed the Chinese empire north and west of the Great Wall. Sometimes he joined forces against other nomadic tribes, notably the neighboring Tatars, at the behest of the northern Chinese Jin dynasty. Another crucial ally at this time was his “sworn brother” Jamuka, of the Tangut tribe based in Xi Xia in northeast China.

Through a series of brilliant military campaigns and diplomatic maneuvers, which included the elimination of his

Mongol quiver

This ornate quiver was designed to hold the arrows that mounted Mongol horsemen were capable of aiming and firing at a full gallop. Mongol boys received intensive training in both horsemanship and archery.



former allies Toghrlur and Jamuka, Temüjin made himself lord of all the Mongol tribes. In 1206, at a mass rally, or *kurultai*, Temüjin was proclaimed as Genghis Khan or “universal ruler.”

For more than three decades Genghis Khan led the Mongol confederation in a string of victories and in campaigns that ravaged large areas of Asia and subjugated many millions of people.

Warrior and statesman

In conquering this huge empire, Genghis Khan frequently resorted to psychological warfare, using spies, propaganda, and terror as much as military force. Even today, the ruthless warlord who massacred the inhabitants of vanquished cities is hard to reconcile with the tolerant ruler, genuinely interested in the various belief-systems of his empire: Buddhism, Islam, Nestorian Christianity, Confucianism, and Taoism. Genghis Khan introduced a humane law code, the *Yassa*, across his empire, and outlawed the custom of kidnapping women. Moreover, in bringing order to the Eurasian landmass, he brought stability to the Silk Road (see pp.184–85), facilitating the renewal of East–West trade and cultural contact.

FOUNDER OF YUAN DYNASTY IN CHINA (1216–94)

KUBLAI KHAN

Genghis Khan was grandfather of another famous Mongolian emperor, Kublai Khan. While on his deathbed, the old warrior laid a hand on the young Kublai’s head, a gesture interpreted as a sign of future greatness.

The Mongolian empire reached its greatest extent under Kublai Khan. Having inherited Mongolia and northern China, Kublai Khan added southern China to his dominion. He is celebrated as a unifier of China and the founder of the Yuan imperial dynasty. He is also the “Great Khan” of Marco Polo’s travels, who entertained the Venetians and gave them passports for their journey.



“In military exercises
I am always in
front and in time
of battle I am
never behind.”

WORDS ATTRIBUTED TO GENGHIS KHAN BY
A CHINESE MONK, c. 1224

TIMELINE

- **c. 1162** Birth of Temüjin.
- **c. 1170** Disinherited after the murder of his father, a minor chieftain. This means that Temüjin, his siblings, and his mother have to hunt, fish, and gather wild berries for their survival.
- **c. 1180** Marries Börte, to whom he was betrothed as a young boy.
- **c. 1182** Captured and held captive by a rival tribe, but escapes.
- **c. 1184** Temüjin’s wife, Börte, is abducted by a rival clan. Temüjin rescues her with the help of his patron Toghrlur and ally Jamuka.
- **c. 1185** Börte gives birth to a baby boy, named Jochi. Although Temüjin acknowledges him as his son, his paternity is questioned by other members of his family.
- **1190** Unites the Mongol clans, and sets up the humane *Yassa* law code.
- **1201** Defeats his former ally Jamuka.
- **1202** After a victorious campaign against the Tartars, Temüjin is made Toghrlur’s heir-apparent.
- **1203** Campaigns against former patron Toghrlur and his supporters; accidental death of Toghrlur.
- **1206** Is proclaimed Genghis Khan.
- **1209** Tangut kingdom of Xi Xia (northeast China) acknowledges Genghis Khan as overlord.
- **1215** Siege and fall of Zhongdu (Beijing), capital of the Jin empire.
- **1215** Birth of Kublai, son of Genghis Khan’s youngest son Tolui and of Jamuka’s daughter Sorghaghtani Beki, later Kublai Khan.
- **1218** Defeats Kuchlug to annex the Kara-Khitans Khanate of central Asia.
- **1218** Two of Genghis Khan’s generals raid southern Russia, Georgia, and the Ukraine.
- **1218** Commercial caravan and a delegation of envoys from Genghis Khan are massacred by a provincial governor of the state of Khwarezm.
- **1219–25** Unleashes a campaign of conquest and ferocious reprisal against the Khwarezmid empire, which comprised parts of present-day Iran and Afghanistan. In the process, the Silk Road cities of Samarkand, Bukhara, and Nishapur are utterly devastated.
- **1220** Karakorum becomes Genghis Khan’s headquarters, or capital.
- **1227** Defeats rebellious vassal kingdom, the Tangut kingdom of Xi Xia.
- **1227** Dies from a fever contracted after a fall from his horse on campaign in Xi Xia. In keeping with his request for a secret burial place, his supporters slaughter every living creature that crosses the path of the funeral procession. Each of Genghis Khan’s surviving sons inherits his own khanate, which they rule under his third son, Ögedei, the new Great Khan.



GENGHIS KHAN’S COFFIN